



TERTULLIAN AGAINST PRAXEAS

I. MANIFOLD are the ways in which the devil has shown his enmity to the truth. He has at length striven to shatter it by defending it. He claims that there is but one God, the all-powerful Creator of the universe, in order to make a heresy even out of that one. He says that the Father Himself descended into the virgin, that He likewise was born of her, and Himself suffered; even that He Himself is Jesus Christ. The serpent forgot himself; for when trying Jesus Christ after He had been baptised by John, he approached Him as Son of God, knowing full well that God had a Son, even from the very Scriptures out of which he was then building up the temptation.¹ “If thou art the Son of God, speak that these stones become loaves”; again: “If thou art the Son of God, cast thyself down hence; for it is written, that He”—that is, the Father—“hath given His messengers charge over thee, to uphold thee by their hands lest anywhere thou shouldst strike thy foot against a stone.” Or shall he upbraid the Gospels with falsehood, and say: “It is Matthew’s and Luke’s

Matt. iv. 3

Matt. iv. 6
cf. Luke
iv. 9-11

¹ For the missing present participle of *sum* to be supplied with *certus*, cf. Hoppe, pp. 144 f.

concern, not mine? It was God Himself that I approached, the All-powerful Himself whom I assayed hand to hand; it was for that reason that I approached, it was also for that reason that I attacked. But if He had been merely the Son of God, I should never have deigned to tempt Him." In truth, however, it is rather "he himself" who "has been a liar" "from the beginning," he and any man he has privily sent of his own accord, such as Praxeas. For it was Praxeas who first, from Asia,¹ imported this kind of perversity to Roman soil, a restless being in other² respects, and puffed up besides with boasting about his martyrdom, which consisted merely in an ordinary brief, if irksome,³ period in prison; whereas, even if he had "surrendered his body to be burnt up," it would have "profited him nothing," as he had not "the love" of God, whose "gifts" he even violated. For, when the then bishop of Rome⁴ was now recognising the prophecies of Montanus, Prisca and Maximilla, and as the result of that recognition

cf. John
viii. 44

cf. I Cor.
xiii. 3

cf. I Cor.
xii. 4, etc.

¹ Asia means, of course, the Roman province of the name, roughly the western third of what we call Asia Minor.

² For the post-classical use of *alias* = *aliter*, see *Thesaurus* s.v., and Hoppe, pp. 110 f.

³ For the hypallage here, see Hoppe, p. 87.

⁴ The bishop referred to was either Victor (so Allix, Oehler) or his predecessor Eleutherus (so Blondel, Neander). For the traditional lists of these bishops see C. H. Turner in *Journ. Theol. Studies*, vol. xviii. pp. 108, 118. The date of Victor's accession is put at M. Aurelius XVII (= A.D. 163), cf. Turner, p. 115, but the true date appears to be 189. Montanus founded Montanism in Phrygia about the middle of the second century. Prisca and Maximilla were women followers of his. All prophesied and maintained the superiority of spiritual gifts over official position in the Church. See d'Alès, chap. ix.